Cheap as Dirt

Cattle, Gold, and the End of the Open Range

CHUNK HISTORY · NARRATION SCRIPT · 2,290 WORDS · ABOUT 15:00

> ***Driving question:*** *Anyone with a horse and some nerve could try to get rich on cattle. How did it go from that to Russell's starving steer in about twenty years, and who actually got rich?*

Underlined = vocabulary card on screen · *italic* = spoken with emphasis · timestamps are estimates until the voice is recorded

0:00 The Last of the Five Thousand (cold open)

[matter-of-fact] This little painting was a message to a boss. It told him his cattle were dead.

Montana, the winter of 1886. A businessman in Helena owned about five thousand cattle out on the plains. He wrote to his foreman. How had the herd come through?

The foreman didn't know how to put it in words. So, the way the story is usually told, a young cowhand named Charlie Russell painted this instead. And the foreman sent it.

Look at it. One steer, alone in the snow. Look at the hip bones. Now look behind him. [firmly] Those are wolves. They're waiting.

Russell called it *Waiting for a Chinook*. A chinook is a warm wind that melts the snow. It never came. The picture has another name, too. *The Last of the Five Thousand.*

[curious] Twenty years earlier, cattle were one of the surest ways to get rich in America. Anyone with a horse and some nerve could try. So here's the question. How did it go from that, to this? And who actually got rich?

[thoughtful] The answer is a story about who owned the grass. And we'll come back to this steer.

It starts in Texas, with too many cows and no money at all.

1:24 Four-Dollar Cows

Last time, I promised you a man with an idea and about five million cows. Here are the cows.

Texas, 1865. The war is over. Confederate soldiers come home to a state with almost no money. But their cattle had run wild for four years, and multiplied. By most estimates, there were about five million longhorns in Texas.

Here's the problem. In Texas, a steer was worth about four dollars, [wry] if you could find anyone with four dollars. In Chicago, the same steer sold for about forty.

Northern cities were hungry for beef. So, why not just take the cattle north? [matter-of-fact] That's where the railroad comes in.

Remember the rail lines from last time? One of them was pushing west across Kansas. In 1867, a cattle dealer from Illinois named Joseph McCoy picked a tiny stop on that line called Abilene. He later described it as about a dozen log huts. McCoy built pens, a hotel and a shipping yard, and sent word to Texas. Bring your cattle here.

That first season, about thirty-five thousand head came up the trail.

So, stack it up. Cheap cows in Texas. Hungry cities in the North. A railroad in between. [firmly] That means a cow became a ticket.

And you didn't even need to own land to feed them. Most of the Plains was **open range**: public land with no fences, where anyone's cattle could graze for free.

All you had to do was walk them to the railroad. About a thousand miles.

2:56 The Long Drive

The routes they walked became some of the most famous roads in America. And none of them were roads.

Watch the map. The first big one was the **Chisholm Trail**, from south Texas, up through Indian Territory, today's Oklahoma, to Abilene. Later, the Western Trail ran farther west, to Dodge City. And one went another way entirely. The Goodnight-Loving Trail ran west across Texas, then north, up the Pecos River into New Mexico. Hold onto that one.

Picture one drive. About twenty-five hundred cattle. A crew of maybe ten or twelve men. Ten to fifteen miles a day, for two or three months.

Up front, the trail boss. Then the cook, with his wagon. And at the very back, the newest riders, eating dust all day.

Three things could end a drive. One: a stampede. A clap of thunder at night, and the whole herd runs. Two: rivers. Cattle and men drowned at the crossings. Three: the people whose land you were crossing. In Indian Territory, nations like the Cherokee charged a toll for every herd, sometimes paid in cattle.

Between the late 1860s and the mid-1880s, millions of cattle went north this way. Estimates run from five to ten million.

The towns at the end of the trail boomed for a season, then the trade moved west with the railroad. [wry] In Abilene, after just a few years, the farmers asked the Texans to take their cattle somewhere else.

But one pair of ranchers went the other way. And their best customer was the United States Army.

4:32 Beef for Bosque Redondo

In 1866, two Texas ranchers, Charles Goodnight and Oliver Loving, gathered about two thousand cattle and drove them west, along the Pecos River, to a fort in New Mexico called Fort Sumner.

[serious] Why there? Because next to the fort, the Army was holding about eight thousand Diné, or Navajo, people, along with hundreds of Mescalero Apache. Soldiers had forced the Diné to walk there, hundreds of miles, a march they call the Long Walk. The camp was called **Bosque Redondo**. The land couldn't grow enough food. People were going hungry, and the Army needed beef.

So let's say it plainly. One of the most famous cattle trails in America began as a way to feed a prison camp.

Goodnight and Loving sold their steers there for about twelve thousand dollars in gold.

Goodnight is also usually credited with inventing the **chuck wagon**: an old Army wagon with a box of shelves and drawers built onto the back, so a cook could feed a crew on the trail. The lid folded down into a table. Before long, nearly every drive had one.

The next year, Loving was badly wounded in a fight with Comanche warriors, and he died at Fort Sumner. Goodnight later carried his body home to Texas, hundreds of miles.

Hold onto Bosque Redondo. We'll come back to it in the last episode.

So who were the men actually riding these trails?

5:59 Who the Cowboys Were

[playful] You probably picture a cowboy from the movies. Tall, white, older, and doing pretty well. [wry] The real thing was usually none of those.

Most cowboys were teenagers or young men. They were paid about twenty-five to forty dollars a month. About a dollar a day.

And a lot of them weren't white. Historians estimate that about one in four cowboys on the Texas trails was Black. Many had been enslaved on Texas ranches before the war. Now they did the same work for wages.

And here's a strange turn. Before the war, this same Texas country was a place enslaved people ran from. Not north. South. Across the Rio Grande, to Mexico, where slavery was illegal. Somewhere between three and ten thousand made it. Twenty years later, in some of that same country, free Black men rode for pay.

On the trail, a Black cowboy often ate, slept and worked the same as everyone else. In town, at the end of it, he ran into the same color line he had left. Both things were true.

One of them, Nat Love, wrote a memoir. He called himself "Deadwood Dick." [amused] Some of his stories are probably tall tales.

And then there were the vaqueros, Mexican cowboys, who were working cattle in Texas long before it was part of the United States. They taught the trade. You can hear it in the words. Lariat, from *la reata*. Chaps, from *chaparreras*. Ranch, from *rancho*. Rodeo. Bronco.

[serious] In 1874, two things happened that would help end all of this. The first was in the Black Hills.

7:36 1874

1874.

First, a promise. In 1868, the United States signed a treaty with the Lakota at Fort Laramie. It set aside a huge reservation, including the **Black Hills**, which the Lakota held sacred, for their "absolute and undisturbed use and occupation." Hold onto that treaty. It's where the last episode begins.

Six years later, in the summer of 1874, the Army sent about a thousand men into the Black Hills, led by George Armstrong Custer. Officially, they were looking for a place to build a fort. They also brought along two miners.

[firmly] The miners found gold. The reports that came back said it was right there, at the grass roots.

Newspapers did the rest. Prospectors started pouring in. The Army tried to keep them out at first, then mostly stopped trying.

In 1875, the government offered to buy the Black Hills from the Lakota, for about six million dollars, or rent them. [firmly] The Lakota said no.

It didn't matter. By the summer of 1876, a mining camp called Deadwood, on treaty land, had thousands of people in it.

So, stack it up. A treaty. An expedition. A rumor. A rush. [serious] That means a promise on paper lasted about six years, once someone found gold underneath it.

So who actually got the gold?

8:55 Who Got the Gold (+ plug)

Every gold rush goes the same way, in three steps.

Step one: a man with a pan in a creek. The gold is loose in the gravel, and anyone can wash it out. That's called **placer mining**.

Step two: the easy gold runs out. The rest is locked inside solid rock, deep underground.

Step three: getting it out takes shafts, machines, and a mill that crushes rock day and night. And that takes money. A lot of it.

In 1877, a group of rich California investors, led by George Hearst, bought a claim in the Black Hills called the **Homestake**, for seventy thousand dollars. [impressed] It became one of the richest gold mines in the world. Over forty million ounces of gold. It didn't close until 2002.

So, stack it up. A free-for-all, then hard rock, then a company. That means most miners ended up where they'd started. Working for wages. Just underground.

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[light] Quick thing, before the fences go up. If you're enjoying this series, subscribe. It's free. [wry] Cheap as dirt, even. Hold onto that phrase.

10:01 Cheap as Dirt

In 1874, the same year as the gold, a farmer in DeKalb, Illinois, named Joseph Glidden got a patent for a new kind of fence. Look at the drawing. Two wires twisted together. And every few inches, a short, sharp barb, wrapped on tight so it couldn't slide. **barbed wire**.

That mattered, because the Plains had almost no trees. A wooden fence meant hauling lumber for hundreds of miles. Wire was cheap, light and fast to put up.

A young salesman named John Gates built a corral of barbed wire in the middle of San Antonio, filled it with longhorns, and let them try to break out. They couldn't. And the way the story's told, his pitch was this. [playful] "Light as air, stronger than whiskey, and cheap as dirt."

So who fenced? There are two ways to see it. Farmers fenced to keep cattle out of their crops, and they had a point. Big ranchers fenced too, sometimes around public land they didn't own, and around the water. And the small ranchers and cowboys who depended on the open range found it closed.

So some of them got out wire cutters. In 1883, a drought year in Texas, fence cutting spread across the state, mostly at night. The **range wars** had begun. In 1884, Texas made fence cutting a prison crime.

That means the open range didn't end with one battle. It ended one fence post at a time.

[serious] But the fences changed the range slowly. The weather did it in one winter.

11:35 The Big Die-Up (slower: speed 0.92)

[serious] By the 1880s, the northern plains were crowded.

Count the reasons. One: too many cattle. Investors from the East, and even from Britain and Scotland, had poured money into ranches on the open range. The herds had grown faster than the grass.

Two: the summer of 1886 was hot and dry. The grass came in thin. The cattle went into the fall already weak.

Three: the winter. Storm after storm. Then, in January 1887, a blizzard that lasted for days. Temperatures fell far below zero. The snow froze into a hard crust, and the cattle couldn't dig through it to the grass underneath.

They drifted with the wind, until they hit a fence, or a ravine. And they stopped.

In the spring, the snow melted. The creeks were full of dead cattle.

Cowboys called it the **Big Die-Up**. Nobody knows exactly how many died. In Montana, some estimates say more than half of all the cattle on the range.

One of the ranchers who lost a fortune was a young New Yorker with ranches in Dakota Territory, Theodore Roosevelt. That spring, he wrote to a friend. "The losses are crippling."

That's the winter Charlie Russell painted.

What came after was a different kind of ranching. Smaller herds. Fenced pastures. Hay, cut in the summer and stored for the winter. Cattle ranching survived, as a business. [firmly] The open range was over.

So, let's go back to the question.

13:11 The Last of the Five Thousand (the answer)

So who actually got rich?

The men with herds, and the men with money behind them. McCoy's cattle trade made fortunes in Kansas. Goodnight, with money from a British investor, built one of the biggest ranches in Texas. The Homestake made its owners rich for more than a century.

The cowboys got wages. Some, especially Black and Mexican cowboys, found more freedom on the trail than they'd had anywhere else, until they rode into town.

The miners got wages too.

And the Lakota got a treaty that lasted until someone found gold under it.

[warmly] Let's write it down. Row two. The promise: anyone with nerve can get rich. Who got it? Herd owners, investors and the Homestake's owners, and some cowboys, for a while. Who didn't? Most cowboys and miners, the small ranchers who were fenced out, and the Lakota, whose land was mined.

So look at the steer again.

[thoughtful] It took about twenty years to turn four-dollar cows into a fortune. [pause] It took one winter to turn it into a painting.

[light] The cowboys moved on. The farmers stayed. And they'd been promised something even bigger than grass. The land itself.

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[warmly] Thanks for watching. If you want more stories like this one, subscribe, and I'll see you next time.